a hint of 'will thoust be my saviour' in his eyes. Even if that wasn't true, she had committed too much to back off now.

"Yes that was true. Was. Open your eyes and look around. The lines at the centres waiting for their ration of water, the complete drought in Delhi, Bengaluru and Hyderabad, don't you think this has opened the eyes of the people? The capital is collapsing and other cities are following suit. Everybody is scared. If anything, this is your time to say 'I told you so'. Not to remain holed up in your little space. You have been vindicated. So drop the cynicism and come save the world."

The bleak scenario was not the rambling of a paranoid mind but a slow dawning reality that had every politician and corporation running for covers. Daily protest marches were erupting across the country against the inaction and apathy of politicians and polluting corporations alike. Although guilty, the individual seemed to want to ignore his and her own complicity in this failure.

"OK, I'll join you, if only to tell you I told you so at the end".

CHAPTER 3

The road was hard and the battle against nature's wrath, embittered. Persevering, Avisa and her team developed several technologies to counter effects of years of wastefulness and blatant disregard for the world's most precious commodity. Yes, water had become a commodity – one that was traded, bought, smuggled and black marketed.

In just 8 short years, the country had gone over the brink. Water rationing had become the norm. Increasing dependence on imports had taken the prices to astronomical levels. *Janta Raj* was in full rage and prediction of State of Emergency was on the tongue of all political pundits.

The day of August 7, 2026 and the name Kumuda, would forever be enshrined in history but the 6 member team meeting on that fateful morning was yet to realise this.

"No, no, no! If we use diesel as fuel, we are just trading one crisis for another. The environmental impact..."

"Dilip, if we don't have this technology up and running, there won't be an environment to worry about! Everything is going to the dogs! At least a diesel fuel source is readily available and we can have the micro plant up and running in a few months. Actual usable water in people's homes. Do you really think they care about the fuel source if we can give them water?", countered Malcolm, the fuel engineer.

Dilip, the other engineer, glared as he geared up for a counter argument. The fuel research team was evenly split upon the choice of fuel to be used to power the micro desalination plant. Avisa and her team had conceptualized a micro desalination plant that could be outfitted in societies to provide drinking and usable water to the residents. The machine itself was cheap to manufacture, thanks to Avisa's resourceful design. Glenn, the automation expert had provided the final touches by designing a system that used lesser moving parts in the equipment increasing its life cycle and applying cutting edge factory automation to reduce manufacturing costs. The sticking point was the fuel source.

Breaking a new path is hard and tough. New technology is not easy but when you have your eyes on the prize, nothing is impossible

Historically, land space and electricity costs had been the prohibitive factors in applying this technology countrywide. Micro plants solved the first problem but any power source currently used was either directly or indirectly detrimental to the environment or made the costs prohibitive.

Kalinda, the nanotechnology expert interjected, "There is another option – nanotube membranes capable of converting static electricity into heat energy. We have made a lot of progress in the last year."

Avisa let the debate play out without taking sides and merely guiding it to keep it on track wherever necessary. Although volatile, she knew that each and everyone of them was passionate about two things – technology and the environment. They had already achieved a lot more in the past 6 years than many countries had achieved in decades. But now she knew it was time to take a decision.

"Kalinda, how confident are you about getting this technology on the road in a few months?"

"Few months, maybe not. Give me a year and I will have a fully functional prototype ready for you."

"OK. Everybody, we are in this for the long term. Unless we can arrive at a holistic solution, there's really no point in doing anything. We are standing on the shoulders of giants and we owe it to them and to ourselves not to cut corners at this point. We will not fall in the trap of money minded corporates! Nanotechnology is the only solution."

Looking around the room, she knew that everybody would throw a 100% behind her decision. They were people she could rely on completely. As simply as that, history was made.

EPILOGUE

Avisa, looked around the Kumuda headquarters building with pride, ten storeys high and housing a thousand employees. From her top floor office, she could see the sprawling factory spewing out ten thousand units daily of Shudh Jal, the micro desalination plant.

"Congratulations on winning the Nobel Peace Prize", said Robin with a warm smile. "So what's next for us?"

Avisa smiled as she picked up an apple off her desk and lobbed it to Robin.